CHAPTER 4

Differentiation: from the rate of change to the tangent

Chapter path

Objectives. Interpret a rate; approximate a derivative; find a tangent; understand failures of differentiability.
Prerequisites. Function values, slope of a line, algebraic manipulation, square root and absolute value.
Yearly reference point. 3-12 November: 8 hours

Diagnostic check: six questions, 10 minutes

Answer without looking at your notes. Indicate the questions for which help is needed. This diagnostic test is not graded.

1. Slope of the line through (1; 2) and (3; 8)?

2. Expand $(2 + \quad h)^2 - 4$.

3. Simplify $\dfrac{4h + h^2}{h}$ if $h \neq 0$.

4. Calculate $\sqrt{0}$ and $\sqrt{0{,}01}$.

5. Calculate $|-3|$ and $|2|$.

6. A line with slope 2 passes through (1; 5). Equation?

After the diagnostic check. Go over the flagged concepts with the teacher; redo a similar question, then explain the rule used.

Oral work and logic. Explain to a classmate why we simplify the rate before letting h tend to 0. Distinguish average and instantaneous speed.

Investigate before formalising

For $f(x) = x^2$, vary h, positive and negative, around 0, keeping point A at x = 1.
Draw three secants; conjecture a limiting line, then determine it without reading the graph.

Organisation. Individual work 5 min, discussion in pairs 5 min, whole-class sharing 5 min.
Keep a record of an attempt, even an unfinished one. A conjecture must then be justified.

4.1 Rates of change and secants

Definition and results

For $a \neq b$ in the domain of f, the rate of change between a and b is $\dfrac{f(b) - f(a)}{b - a}$. This is the slope of the secant through the corresponding points. In context, the unit of the rate is the unit of f divided by that of the variable.

Status and justification. Definition; formula for the slope of a line already studied. With $b = a + h$, $h \neq 0$, the rate becomes $\dfrac{[f(a + h) - f(a)]}{h}$.

Worked example. For $f(x) = x^2$, between 1 and 3, the rate is $\dfrac{9 - 1}{3 - 1}$ = 4. Between 1 and 1 + h, it equals $2 + h$. The slopes for $h = 0{,}1$ and $h = -0{,}1$ are 2.1 and 1.9.

Watch out

The rate is not $\dfrac{f(b)}{f(a)}$; h is a step, positive or negative depending on the domain.

Immediate application. Calculate the rate of $f(x) = x^2 + 3x$ between 2 and 2 + h.

4.2 Derivative at a point

Definition and results

f is differentiable at a when the rate $\dfrac{[f(a + h) - f(a)]}{h}$ tends to a real number as h tends to 0, in the domain. This real number is $f\prime(a)$. An intuitive approach to limits is used here. In kinematics, if f gives a position in metres and time in seconds, the derivative represents an instantaneous speed in m s $^{-1}$.

Status and justification. For $f(x) = x^2$, the rate at a equals 2 $a + h$, which approaches 2 a ; so $f\prime(a) = 2a$. This calculation will reappear as a derivative function in Chapter 6.

Worked example. For $s(t) = t^2 + 3t$, the rate around 2 is 7 + h, therefore $s\prime(2) = 7\ \mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$. The average speed on [2; 3] is 8 m s $^{-1}$; it is not the speed at time 2.

Watch out

We do not replace h by 0 in an unsimplified quotient: we would get a division by 0.

Immediate application. For $f(x) = 3x^2 - 2x$, calculate $f\prime(1)$ from the rate.

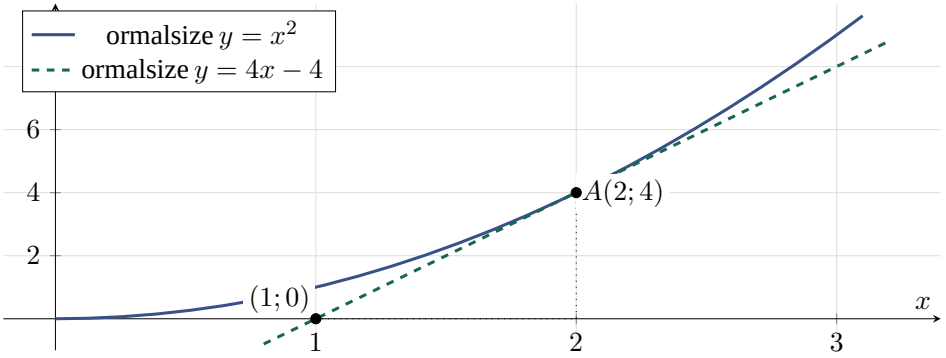
4.3 Tangent and linear approximation

Definition and results

If f is differentiable at a, the tangent at the point ($a; f(a)$) has equation $y = f(a) + f\prime(a)(x - a)$. For small h, we use $f(a + h) \approx f(a) + f\prime(a)h$. This local approximation does not give on its own a bound on the error.

Status and justification. The tangent has slope $f\prime(a)$ and passes through $(a; f(a))$. In $y = f\prime(a)x + p$, substituting this point gives $p = f(a) - af\prime(a)$, hence the equation.

Worked example. For $f(x) = x^2$ at 2, tangent $y = 4 + 4(x - 2) = 4x - 4$. We approximate 2 ,01^2 by 4 + 4(0 ,01) = 4,04; the exact value is 4 ,0401, error 0 ,0001 $= h^2$.



The tangent at A also passes through (1; 0). Its slope is $\frac{4-0}{2-1}$ = 4. The dashed line makes it possible to distinguish it from the curve, even in black and white.

Watch out

A tangent can meet the curve again elsewhere. "A single common point" is not a definition.

Immediate application. We are given $f(3)$ = 5 and $f\prime(3) = -2$. Write the tangent and approximate $f(3{,}04)$.

4.4 When differentiability fails

Definition and results

The square root function is defined on [0; + ∞[but is not differentiable at 0. The absolute value fn is defined on ℝ but is not differentiable at 0. Being defined or having a continuous curve doesn't ensure differentiability.

Status and justification. For $h > 0$, $\dfrac{\sqrt{h} - 0}{h} = \dfrac{1}{\sqrt{h}}$, which does not tend to a finite real number as h approaches 0. For $|x|$, the rate $\dfrac{|h|}{h}$ is 1 on the right and -1 on the left: no common value.

Worked example. For $|x|$, the secants through the origin all have slope 1 on the right and -1 to on the left. The corner point does not have a unique tangent with finite slope. For the square root, the limiting direction is vertical; there is no real derivative.

Watch out

A very steep slope is not proof of non-differentiability; we must explain the behaviour of the rate.

Immediate application. Justify that $g(x) = |x - 2|$ is not differentiable at 2. Also study the differentiability of $x \mapsto \overline{x}$ at 0 via its rate.

Exercise path

Start with exercises 1 and 2. Then choose exercise 3 or 4 without help. Exercises 5 to 7 are a bank of transfer, investigation or programming tasks: the teacher assigns one. Exercise 8 is revisited later.

Exercise 4.1 · Two secants

The function f is defined on ℝ by $f(x) = x^2 - 1$. Let A be the point of its curve with x = 1.

1. Calculate the slope of the secant joining A to the point on the curve with x-coordinate 2.

2. Repeat the calculation with the point of the curve with x-coordinate 1 ,1.

3. After studying the derivative at a point, determine $f\prime(1)$ and compare this value with the two rates calculated. Explain what changes when the second point approaches A.

Exercise 4.2 · One tangent

Consider the function $f(x) = 2x^2 + 1$, defined on ℝ. The aim is to determine the equation of its tangent at the point with x-coordinate -1, starting from the rate of change.

1. For $h \neq 0$, write then simplify $\dfrac{f(-1 + h) - f(-1)}{h}$.

2. Deduce $f\prime(-1)$. Also calculate $f(-1)$.

3. Write the equation y = mx + p of the tangent and check that it passes through the point of contact.

Exercise 4.3 · Marginal cost

A company uses the model $C(q) = q^2 + 20q + 100$, where $q \geq 0$ denotes the quantity produced and $C(q)$ its cost in monetary units. The model extends the quantity to a real variable in order to study small variations in production.

1. Calculate $C(10)$ and $C(11)$, then the rate of change of C between 10 and 11. Interpret this rate in the context.
2. From the rate between 10 and 10 + h, determine $C'(10)$.
3. Compare the two results. Explain why the cost of one extra unit is not exactly equal to the derivative in this model.

Exercise 4.4 · Read a tangent

This exercise has two independent situations. A tangent to a curve is a line: another point on this line does not necessarily lie on the curve.

1. On the figure in the section on the tangent, read the coordinates of two points on the green line. Deduce its slope and check the value stated in the caption.
2. In another situation, the tangent to the graph of a function f at the point $A(2; 3)$ passes through $B(4; 2)$. Determine $f(2)$ and $f'(2)$. Can we deduce $f(4)$?
3. Use this tangent to give an approximate value of $f(2{,}1)$. Show the sign " approximately equal" in the conclusion.

Exercise 4.5 · Checking an approximation

We want to approximate $1{,}98^2$ without first carrying out the multiplication. We use the tangent to the curve of the square function at the point with x-coordinate 1.

1. Write the equation of this tangent and deduce the desired approximation.
2. Then calculate the exact value of $1{,}98^2$. The error is defined as "exact value minus approximate value": calculate this error and state its sign.
3. Explain the result from the identity $(1 + h)^2 = 1 + 2h + h^2$.

Exercise 4.6 · Tangent and intersection

The function f is defined on $\mathbb{R}$ by $f(x) = x^3$. We assume that $f'(1) = 3$. A student claims that a tangent and a curve always have exactly one point in common.

1. Determine the equation of the tangent to the graph of f at the point with x-coordinate 1.
2. Check by expanding that $x^3 - 3x + 2 = (x - 1)^2(x + 2)$.
3. Determine all points of intersection of the curve and this tangent. Is the pupil's claim correct?

Exercise 4.7 · Numerical secants

To study the square function near 1, we define, for $h \neq 0$,

$$T(h) = \frac{(1+h)^2 - 1}{h}.$$

Use the six values 0,1, 0,01, 0,001 and their opposites.

1. Write a Python function that calculates $T(h)$, then produce a table of six results.
2. Conjecture the value of the derivative of the square function at 1.
3. Simplify algebraically $T(h)$ to justify the conjecture. Explain why testing numerical values is not enough, on its own, to prove the result.

Exercise 4.8 · Delayed review

The reciprocal function is defined by $f(x) = \frac{1}{x}$ for $x \neq 0$. It is studied near 1.

1. State the forbidden values of h in the rate $\frac{f(1+h) - f(1)}{h}$, then simplify it.
2. Deduce $f'(1)$ and the equation of the tangent at 1.
3. Use this tangent to approximate $\frac{1}{1{,}02}$. Keep the distinction between exact value and approximate value.

Independent work. Do only the task assigned at the end of the session, as set in the dated scheme of work: 10-20 min maximum. The exercises depend on the concepts already studied; some questions are therefore postponed. Revisit exercise 8 one week after the chapter (10 min). If the planned time is exceeded, note the difficulty and bring your attempts; do not try to do the whole reserve.

To be done in the CQFD textbook

These exercises are done in your textbook. The scheme of work gives the session; they replace the homework planned for that day (10 to 20 minutes in total).

CQFD, exercise 17 p. 127, all questions. Read two points on each tangent; write the difference quotient rather than estimating its steepness.

CQFD, exercise 19 p. 127, questions 1 and 2. Distinguish the y-coordinate of the point of contact from the slope of the tangent line.

MCQ 1: understand and choose

Five teaching questions with a single answer. Choose one answer per question; then explain one distractor. This chapter format does not reproduce the official format of the EAM.

1. Rate of x^2 between 1 and 2:

   A. 2
   B. 3
   C. 1
   D. 4

2. If $f(1) = 4$, $f'(1) = 2$, tangent:

   A. $y = 2x + 2$
   B. $y = 4x + 2$
   C. $y = 2x + 4$
   D. $y = x + 3$

3. The derivative at a point is

   A. a function
   B. an area
   C. an x-coordinate
   D. a real number if the derivative exists

4. For x^2 at 3, derivative:

   A. 9
   B. 3
   C. 6
   D. 12

5. The approximation of $f(a + h)$ is

   A. $f(a)f'(a)$
   B. $f(a) + hf'(a)$
   C. $f(a) + f'(h)$
   D. $hf(a)$

MCQ 2: understand and choose

Five teaching questions with a single answer. Choose one answer per question; then explain one distractor. This chapter format does not reproduce the official format of the EAM.

1. $\sqrt{x}$ at 0 is

   A. differentiable with derivative 0
   B. differentiable with derivative 1
   C. not differentiable
   D. undefined

2. $\dfrac{|h|}{h}$ for $h < 0$ equals

   A. -1
   B. 1

C. 0

D. h

3. A tangent with slope 0 is

A. vertical

B. oblique

C. impossible

D. horizontal

4. Position in m and time in s: unit of the derivative

A. m^2

B. $\mathrm{m\,s}^{-1}$

C. $\mathrm{s\,m}^{-1}$

D. m

5. For f differentiable at a, replacing $f(a+h)$ by $f(a)+hf'(a)$ is in general

A. an exact identity

B. a definition of h

C. a local approximation

D. always false, even for an affine function

True or false? Justify.

1. A tangent can never meet a curve again.

2. The absolute value function is differentiable at 0.

3. An affine function $mx+p$ has derivative m at every real number.

Personal review

I state the domain and that h is non-zero; I read a slope; I use the point of tangency; I distinguish exact and approximate.
For each objective, indicate: mastered without help; achieved with help; needs more work. Write an example and a mistake to avoid.